

Persian, Step by Step, Root by Root

A gentle, etymology-driven introduction to Iranian Persian

Adhithya Rajasekaran

Starter edition — five short chapters, with more being written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Persian is set in
Noto Naskh Arabic (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Persian one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It assumes no Persian and no Perso-Arabic script: every section takes one small expression, introduces only the letters and grammar that expression needs, connects it to words you may already know, and ends by asking for it back. Persian reads right to left — but you will be reading real words long before you have met the whole alphabet.

This is contemporary Iranian Persian. Romanization stays beside the script for now and fades as your reading grows. Where formal written and colloquial forms diverge, both are labelled rather than quietly averaged; Dari and Tajik are relatives of this language, not substitutes for it, and are not smuggled in here.

Persian vocabulary comes in historical layers. Some everyday words are inherited Iranian forms; many others arrived through Arabic and now follow Persian pronunciation and grammar completely. Etymology in this book is practical — it gives a word a handhold in your memory — and never a claim that a borrowed word is less fully Persian today.

This is a starter edition: five short chapters, complete in themselves, with more being written.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Persian out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings and responses	1
1.1 سلام (<i>salâm</i>) — hello through peace	1
1.2 ممنون (<i>mamnun</i>) — thank you	2
1.3 بـله (<i>bale</i>) — yes	2
1.4 نه (<i>na</i>) — no, and an inherited bridge	3
2 Give your name	5
2.1 اسم من ... است (<i>esm-e man ... ast</i>) — my name is	5
3 Ask and Answer Names	7
3.1 shomâ / to	7
3.2 chist	8
3.3 esm-e shomâ chist?	9
3.4 khoshvaghtam	10
3.5 Practice	11
4 How Are You?	13
4.1 hâl	13
4.2 chetor	14
4.3 hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?	15
4.4 khub	15
4.5 khubam, mamnun	16
4.6 Practice	17
5 Take Leave	19
5.1 khodâ	19
5.2 hâfez	20
5.3 khodâ hâfez	21

5.4 Practice	21
A note on sources	23

Chapter 1

Greetings and responses

This chapter builds one miniature exchange in dependency order: greet, thank, answer yes, answer no. Four short expressions are enough to establish the direction of the script, joining, one non-joining letter, omitted short vowels, and the contrast between borrowed and inherited vocabulary. Companion lessons: FA-C01-*.md.

1.1 سلام (*salâm*) — hello through peace

Read only what this expression needs

Persian runs **right to left**. Read سلام from its right edge: س *s*, ل *l*, ا long *â*, م *m*. Most letters join inside a word. The tall ا is a non-joiner on its left side, so the final م begins a new stroke group. No other letters are required yet.

Where the expression came from

Salâm means “hello” and evokes peace. Persian borrowed it from Arabic, whose consonant family **s-l-m** carries ideas of peace, safety, and wholeness. Hebrew *shalom* belongs to the same older Semitic family. The word is borrowed history and completely ordinary modern Persian at once.

Use it now

Say سلام to one person or a group. It is a neutral, friendly greeting. Hear it, answer with the same word, and resist adding any grammar yet.

One-minute checkpoint

Read سلام from right to left. Which letter carries the long *â*? Point to ل, cover the romanization, and say *salâm* once.

1.2 ممنون (*mamnun*) — thank you**Read only what this expression needs**

Reuse final م from سلام, now at the right edge where reading begins. The visible sequence is م *m*, م *m*, ن *n*, و long *u*, ن *n*. Persian usually omits short vowels, so the first *a* is learned with the whole word. Here و carries the long *u*.

Where the expression came from

Persian received *mamnun* from Arabic. It describes someone as grateful or obliged and belongs to the Arabic **m–n–n** family associated with favor or kindness. In current Persian conversation, the whole word is simply a useful “thanks.”

Use it now

Build the smallest exchange: A says سلام; B answers سلام; A adds ممنون. Treat each expression as one social move.

One-minute checkpoint

Which visible letter carries long *u* in ممنون? Point to و, then say *salâm* — *mamnun* without looking.

1.3 بله (*bale*) — yes**Read only what this expression needs**

Read three letters: ب *b*, ل *l*, ه *h*. The short *a* and *e* are supplied by the reader rather than written as separate letters. The final ه remains visible even though careful speech ends with a light vowel-like sound rather than a forceful English *h*.

Use it now

Bale is a standard polite affirmative. A more casual answer exists, but one reliable “yes” is enough now: *bale*, *mamnun* — yes, thank you.

One-minute checkpoint

Cover *bale*. Read بله; name the two short vowels that the writing leaves implicit; answer “yes” once.

1.4 نه (*na*) — no, and an inherited bridge**Read only what this expression needs**

You already know final ه from بله and ن from ممنون. Put ن on the right and read نه: *n* plus an unwritten short *a*.

Where the expression came from

Unlike the two Arabic loans at the start of this chapter, Persian *na* continues an old Indo-Iranian negative family. Related forms occur across Iranian and Indo-Aryan languages. This is the first bridge from Persian toward Hindi and Urdu: not an instruction to learn those forms now, just a reason the tiny word may feel familiar later.

Use it now

Contrast only the answer: بله *bale* — yes; نه *na* — no. Ask yourself a harmless yes/no question and answer it both ways.

One-minute checkpoint

Without looking back, produce the four-step chain: hello, thank you, yes, no. Then read سلام, ممنون, بله, نه in the same order.

Chapter 2

Give your name

The first chapter supplied social moves. This one adds a single sentence and a single grammar idea: Persian's linking vowel, *ezafe*. Companion lesson: FA-C02-esm-e-man.md.

2.1 اسم من ... است (*esm-e man ... ast*) — my name is ...

Read the Persian phrase from right to left while keeping its spoken word order:

اسم من سارا است
esm-e man Sârâ ast — My name is Sara.

Read only what this expression needs

The phrase reuses more than it appears to. In اسم *esm*, you already recognize ا, س, and م. In من *man*, both letters came from ممنون. The final word است *ast* begins with familiar ا and س; only ت *t* is new. Short vowels remain mostly implicit.

Use it now

Assemble four pieces:

1. اسم *esm* — name;
2. a spoken *-e* — the linker called **ezafe**;
3. من *man* — I/me, interpreted here as the owner;
4. your name, followed by است *ast* — is.

Only one reusable pattern is due: **noun + -e + owner**. Do not expand it into a table of possessive grammar yet.

Where the expression came from

The sentence displays two historical layers side by side. *Esm* is an Arabic loan related to Arabic *ism*. *Man* and *ast* belong to Persian's inherited Iranian core. Borrowed nouns and inherited grammar now work together as one Persian sentence.

One-minute checkpoint

What links *esm* to *man*? Say the normally unwritten *-e*. Then replace Sara with your own name and produce the full careful sentence once.

What is deliberately deferred

Everyday speech often shortens the final copula, and Persian has familiar and polite ways to ask another person's name. Those are later lessons. Keeping the full است visible here lets a new reader account for every part before conversational reductions begin.

Chapter 3

Ask and Answer Names

3.1 شما / تو — two relationships inside “you”

Say **esm-e man ... ast** with your own name. To turn that sentence around, you next need a safe word for the other person.

The two words

Persian	read	use
شما	<i>shomâ</i>	one person respectfully, or more than one person
تو	<i>to</i>	one familiar person

In شما, meet ش *sh*; its three dots distinguish it from س *s*. Final ا carries long *â*. In تو, و has its *o* value rather than the long *u* it had in ممنون. Learn the sound from the whole word.

Grammar Lens: begin respectfully

Persian uses plural **shomâ** for respectful singular address, much as Russian uses *vy* and French uses *vous*. Use **shomâ** with an unfamiliar adult or in a first meeting. Use **to** after the relationship is familiar. English once made a similar distinction but now uses *you* for both.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian **to** belongs to the ancient Indo-European familiar-“you” family: English **thou**, Latin *tū*, and Sanskrit *tvam* are relatives. The word is old; the social choice carried by it is current.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a new adult — **shomâ**
- a close friend — **to**
- the old family — **to, thou, tū, tvam**

Before you move on

Which form is safest when the relationship is new? (**Shomâ**.) Which is the relative of English *thou*? (**To**.)
Source: Persian Online: Pronouns.

3.2 چیست — “what is?” in one joined word

Which “you” is safe for a new adult? (شما, *shomâ*.) Now add the question engine that will follow “your name.”

You’ll want to know first — چیست

چیست — *chist* — **what is?**

Read from the right: چ *ch*, ی long *i*, س *s*, ت *t*. چ is one of Persian’s four additions to the Arabic alphabet: it uses the same base shape as چ, with three dots below. Meet only this joined form now.

Grammar Lens: two words compressed

chist is the careful fusion of **chi** “what” and **ast** “is.” The opening vowel of *ast* disappears when the pieces join:

chi + ast → **chist**

You already know full **ast** from *esm-e man ... ast*. This lesson changes no copula rule; it gives one high-frequency fused question form.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **chi** + **ast** → **chist**
- *Read it:* چیست from چ to ت
- *Say it:* **chist?** — “what is?”

Before you move on

What two pieces make **chist**? (**Chi** + **ast**.) Which new Persian letter opens it? (چ, *ch*, with three dots below.)

3.3 چیست؟ شما اسم — ask a name respectfully

Give the three ready pieces: **esm-e** “name-of,” **shomâ** respectful “you,” and **chist** “what is?”

The exchange

چيست؟ شما اسم — *esm-e shomâ chist?* — **What is your name?**

The Persian order is transparent once the pieces are known:

name + **-e** + you + what-is?

The spoken ezafe turns **esm-e shomâ** into “your name.” **Chist** stays at the end. No new agreement or verb table is hiding here.

Script: the question mark

Persian ends a written question with ؟. Its curve faces the opposite way from English ?, matching the right-to-left line. Read the sentence from its right edge; meet the punctuation at the far left.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **esm-e shomâ chist?**
- *Say it:* ask, then answer — **esm-e man ... ast**
- *Point to:* to ؟ at the end of the right-to-left question

Before you move on

Ask the question once without reading the romanization. Then answer with the careful name frame you already know.

Source: Persian Online: Introducing Yourself.

3.4 خوشوقتم — pleased to meet you

Ask **esm-e shomâ chist?** and answer **esm-e man ... ast.**

One warm response now closes that tiny meeting.

The exchange

خوشوقتم — *khoshvaghtam* — **Pleased to meet you.**

Treat the joined word as one social move first. خ gives *kh*, like the sound in Scottish *loch*. ش gives *sh*. Persian commonly pronounces ق here with the merged *gh/q* sound of contemporary Iranian speech.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

- **khosh** — pleasant, happy; inherited Persian vocabulary.
- **vaqt** (pronounced *vaght* here) — time; an Arabic loan fully at home in Persian.
- **-am** — I am, the first-person ending.

So the word builds “pleasant-time-I-am” into the idiomatic feeling “I am pleased.” The history is layered; the expression is ordinary modern Persian.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **khoshvaghtam** as one smooth response
- the three pieces — **khosh** + **vaqt** + **-am**
- which piece came from Arabic — **vaqt**

Before you move on

Which response closes the introduction? (**Khoshvaghtam.**) Which three layers can you hear inside it? (**Khosh + vaqt + -am.**)

Source: Persian Online: Introducing Yourself.

3.5 Practice — a complete Persian name exchange

Recall the four moves without adding anything: greet, ask, answer, acknowledge.

The exchange

A: سلام! — *Salâm!* B: سلام! — *Salâm!* A: چیست؟ شما اسم — *Esm-e shomâ chist?* B: است سارا من اسم. — *Esm-e man Sârâ ast.* A: خوشوقتم. — *Khoshvaghtam.* B: ممنون. — *Mamnun.*

Every line is already known. **Shomâ** keeps the first meeting respectful; the answer returns to **man**. The question mark sits at the left end of the right-to-left question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- both voices, using your own name
- the exchange again without romanization
- only the three name moves — question, answer, response

Before you move on

Run the meeting once from **salâm** to **mamnun**. If one line stalls, review that single micro-lesson rather than rereading the whole chapter.

Chapter 4

How Are You?

4.1 حال — the “state” in a wellbeing question

Run only the opening of the meeting you know: **salâm** and the name question. The next move asks about the other person’s present state.

You’ll want to know first — one useful word

حال — *hâl* — state, condition

Read from right to left: ح *h* + ا long *â* + ل *l*. The first letter is a breathier *h* than English normally uses; a clear ordinary *h* is a safe beginner approximation. Keep the whole written word attached to its meaning.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian borrowed **hâl** from Arabic, then uses it with Persian grammar. You will soon say **hâl-e shomâ**, literally “the state of you.” That **-e** is the same spoken ezafe already learned in **esm-e shomâ**.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hâl** — state or condition
- *Read it:* حال from right to left
- *Connect:* an Arabic-rooted noun inside Persian ezafe grammar

Before you move on

What does **hâl** name? (A state or condition.) Which familiar linker will attach an owner to it? (Ezafe **-e**.)
Source: Persian Online: Greetings List.

4.2 چطور — “how?” one layer at a time

Say the Persian noun for a state or condition. (**Hâl**.) Now ask about the manner of that state with one question word.

You’ll want to know first — the question word

چطور؟ — *chetor?* — **how?** / **in what manner?**

You already met چ *ch* in چیست. Here it is followed by ط *t*, و *o*, and ر *r*. The short *e* is not written. Learn the sound from the whole word: *che-tor*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian Online takes چطور apart as Persian چه *che*, “what,” plus the Arabic loan طور *tor*, “manner.” The literal picture is “in what manner?” That layered history is useful memory, but **chetor** is one everyday Persian question word now.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **chetor?** — how?
- *Point to:* to familiar چ at the right edge
- *Rebuild:* **che** “what” + **tor** “manner”

Before you move on

Which part means “what”? (**Che**.) Which borrowed part means “manner”? (**Tor**.)
Source: Persian Online: Interrogatives.

4.3 است؟ چطور شما حال — ask “How are you?” respectfully

Recall **hâl** “state,” **shomâ** respectful “you,” **chetor** “how,” and careful **ast** “is.” The only assembly move is familiar *ezafe*.

The exchange

است؟ چطور شما حال — *hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?* — **How are you?**

Build it without translating English word for word:

state + **-e** + respectful-you + how + is?

The unwritten *ezafe* in **hâl-e shomâ** works exactly like **esm-e shomâ**. Persian asks, literally, “the state of you, in what manner is?”

Grammar Lens: one reliable careful form

This chapter asks you to produce the careful written form with **ast**. Everyday Iranian speech often contracts the end to *چطوره؟ chetore?*; recognize that preview, but keep the uncontracted line until the careful pattern is secure.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?**
- *Trace it:* **hâl-e shomâ** — state-of-you
- *Choose:* careful production now — final **ast**

Before you move on

Ask once from memory. What already-known grammar holds **hâl** and **shomâ** together? (*Ezafe -e*.)
Source: Persian Online: Greetings List.

4.4 خوب — “good” and “well”

Ask **hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?** The smallest positive answer begins with one word.

You'll want to know first — the answer word

خوب — *khub* — good, well

At the right edge, خ is *kh*, made farther back than English *h*. و carries long *u*, as it did in ممنون; final ب closes the word with *b*. Say it as one beat: *khub*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Persian's everyday vocabulary is layered. **Hâl** and the **tor** inside **chetor** came through Arabic; **khub** belongs to the inherited Persian layer. All three are fully ordinary Persian now. History helps memory without ranking one layer as more authentic than another.

Your turn

- Say it: **khub** — good, well
- Read it: خ + long-*u* و + final ب
- Contrast: inherited **khub** beside borrowed **hâl**

Before you move on

Give the answer word once without romanization. Which letter carries its long *u*? (و.)

Source: Persian Online: Greetings List.

4.5 ممنون خوبم، — “I am well, thank you”

Say **khub** “well,” then the thanks you learned in Chapter 1: **mamnun**. One small ending turns the first word into a full answer.

The exchange

ممنون خوبم، — *Khubam, mamnun*. — I am well, thank you.

The new final م is *m*. Attach it directly to خوب: م + خوب → خوبم. Persian script and speech both keep the answer compact.

Grammar Lens: one copula ending, not a table

The attached ending **-am** means “I am” here. Persian Online notes that **خوبم** by itself already means “I am fine”; the separate pronoun **man** is unnecessary. Learn only this useful first-person ending today. The rest of the copula set can arrive one form at a time later.

Your turn

- *Build:* **khub** + **-am** → **khubam**
- *Say it:* **khubam**, **mamnun**
- *Point to:* to final **م** carrying “I am”

Before you move on

What does final **-am** contribute? (“I am.”) Do you need a separate **man** in this answer? (No.)

Sources: Persian Online: Verb “To Be” and Greetings List.

4.6 Practice — a Persian wellbeing exchange

Recall the two moves only: ask about the other person’s state, then answer “I am well, thank you.”

The exchange

A: **است؟ چطور شما حال! سلام** *Salâm! Hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?* B: **ممنون خوبم.** *Khubam, mamnun.*

Every piece is already owned. The question reuses respectful **shomâ**, **ezafe**, and careful **ast**. The answer’s final **-am** carries “I am,” so no new pronoun is hiding between the lines.

Grammar Lens: keep the social choice visible

Use this careful question in a first meeting. You may hear shorter conversational forms, but producing one stable respectful line first prevents script, register, and contraction from arriving as one oversized step.

Your turn

- *Say it:* both voices with the script visible
- *Say it:* both voices without romanization
- *Switch:* ask first, then answer after a pause

Before you move on

Run the exchange once from **salâm** to **mamnun**. If one side stalls, return to that single micro-lesson rather than rereading the chapter.

Chapter 5

Take Leave

5.1 خدا — the Persian half of a farewell

Run the known wellbeing exchange once. The next chapter adds only the final social move: ending that interaction.

You'll want to know first — one word

خدا — *khodâ* — God

Read from right to left: خ *kh* + د *d* + ا long *â*. The short *o* is learned with the word rather than written as a separate letter. Keep the back-of-the-mouth **kh** gentle; clarity matters more than force.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Modern **khodâ** continues Middle Persian *xwadây*, “lord.” The everyday farewell will pair this inherited Persian word with an Arabic loan. That mixed history is normal Persian vocabulary, not an exception to memorize away.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **khodâ** — God
- *Read it:* خدا from the right edge
- *Connect:* modern **khodâ** ← Middle Persian *xwadây* “lord”

Before you move on

Which letter carries the final long â? (l.) Which vowel is heard but not written separately? (The short o.)

Source: Wiktionary: خدا.

5.2 حافظ — “guardian” or “protector”

Read خدا and say **khodâ**. Keep it separate: this lesson adds only the second word behind the farewell.

You’ll want to know first — one word

حافظ — *hâfez* — guardian, protector

Read ح ا ف ا ح from right to left. ا carries long â. In contemporary Persian, final ط is pronounced **z** here, so say *hâ-fez*, not an English *th* sound. The short *e* is part of the learned word and is normally unwritten.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Arabic **ḥāfiẓ** is an active participle from the root **ḥ-f-ẓ**, “guard, preserve.” Persian borrowed the word and uses its Persian pronunciation **hâfez**. Keep the useful meaning first; the root is a memory hook.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **hâfez** — guardian, protector
- *Read it:* حافظ
- *Connect:* Arabic **ḥ-f-ẓ** — guard, preserve

Before you move on

What does **hâfez** contribute to the farewell? (The idea of guarding or protecting.)

Source: American Heritage Dictionary: *hafiz*.

5.3 خدا حافظ — goodbye

Retrieve **khodâ** and **hâfez** separately: “God” + “guardian.”
Now let them become one everyday social move.

The two words — put the known pieces together

خدا حافظ — *khodâ hâfez* — **goodbye**

Persian normally writes the two spoken pieces together. Start with خدا, add حافظ, and read the joined spelling خدا حافظ from the right edge. Keep the two meaning layers available underneath the complete form.

Grammar Lens — a complete wish without a full sentence

The expression carries the protective sense “God [be] guardian,” but everyday speakers use the whole formula simply as **goodbye**. No new verb is required for beginner production. It is a broadly polite, reliable way to end the short respectful interaction built in Chapters 1–4.

Your turn

- *Build:* **khodâ** + **hâfez**
- *Read it:* joined خدا حافظ
- *Use:* say it only when the interaction ends

Before you move on

When do you use **khodâ hâfez**? (At parting, not at the opening.)
Source: Persian Online: Greetings List.

5.4 Practice — open, check, and close

Without looking ahead, retrieve the expression for the beginning and the expression for the end. Do not add a new middle line.

The exchange — the complete interaction

A: سلام! است؟ چطور شما حال! *Salâm! Hâl-e shomâ chetor ast?* B:
 ممنون خوبم. *Khubam, mamnun.* A: خداحافظ. *Khodâ hâfez.* B:
 خداحافظ. *Khodâ hâfez.*

Every line is already learned. **Salâm** opens; **khodâ hâfez** closes. The same farewell works for both voices, so no pronoun, agreement ending, or new register table is hiding inside the practice.

Your turn

- *Choose:* meeting begins → **salâm**
- *Choose:* interaction ends → **khodâ hâfez**
- *Run through:* both voices once with script, once without romanization

Before you move on

Run the full exchange once. If the final line stalls, return only to the assembled-farewell lesson rather than rereading the chapter.

A note on sources

Script descriptions follow the University of Texas at Austin Persian Online writing-system materials; its open greetings vocabulary grounds the Chapter 4 wellbeing forms and the Chapter 5 farewell.